Employee Profiles for BLR Airport Newsletter

This is only a stylized presentation of select employee profiles, not the original.

Dwaipayan Guha Wants to Share His Half of the Food Story

In Chinese, if you were to call a dish 'delicious', you would have to say '好吃', which sounds something like hǎo chī. It's what Dwaipayan Guha thinks after every bite of his 'Chowmein'.

"Any Cantonese and Hunan style preparation is very close to my heart," he says, remembering the time his father first introduced him to the fiery flavours of Indo-Chinese cuisine, back in his homeland Kolkata.

Hailing from a family where the maternal side was from West Bengal and the paternal side from Dhaka Manikgunj, he always had a plate full of eclectic but scrumptious food. It was this marriage of sweet and spice that opened the world of culinary delights for him. And so, from a young age, he has longed to experience food from a diversity of places.

Of his pursuit and passion for documenting his food journey, Dwaipayan says, "Studying hotel management from IHM Kolkata, learning in depth about the culinary history of the world was when I decided to write about food and make people aware of the vastness of this world."

Food, unearthly and glorious in all its vast variety, is a religion to him: the thing that keeps him impassioned about food walks despite the hustle and bustle of his professional life as a hotelier. His weekdays might run long and tiring, but the few moments of respite he receives with food (reviewing restaurants, cooking different cuisines, or helping his mother prepare meals when he's home) he savours, delights, and documents all of it. To him, there is no better reward.

His 13k followers-strong Instagram page, *@Your_introvert_chef*, may have been a pandemic baby (a YouTube channel might be following suit), but Dwaipayan always knew he wanted to share the packets of knowledge locals had shared with him about the cuisines of their lands, eating habits, and everything in between. Following the success of his Instagram page, he even got featured in top publications, writing for big names like the New Indian Express and Hindustan Times. This recognition, coupled with his tremendous love for food, is what keeps him going in his journey to document his experience with diverse cuisines, in hopes that someday he'll be "penned and known as a food connoisseur and share my half of the food story to the world."

A Day in the Life of Sampreeth Kotian

By the time the clock hits 6 AM and the sun peeks from the horizon, Sampreeth Kotian, the Head of Terminal Operations, is already on his phone, taking updates from the night shift team.

Ordinarily, he would check after different zones while in transit, getting the latest updates for the morning shift before reaching the airport. But no matter how much planning goes into his days, the terminal operations are simply unpredictable.

Sampreeth's days are usually tied up in meetings, briefings, and managing crises, both big and small. Even a single issue in any process (passenger processing, flight delays, contactless onboarding, baggage handling, water logging during heavy rains, or fog during winter) can cause disruptions everywhere else. Yet, each operation must take off successfully, and Sampreeth sees to it along with his team.

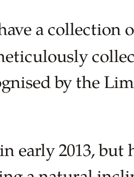
Before the pandemic, the terminal used to welcome lakhs of passengers every single day. Today, the number has gone down to 70,000 passengers a day, but the challenges have only grown ever since. Every time new directives came (from the Karnataka government, APHO, or others), so would sudden changes; still, they had to abide, and fast, because everything had to happen like clockwork.

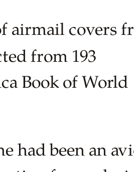
Handling a team as diverse as his, ranging from twenty-two to fifty years old and coming from different backgrounds, was never a cakewalk. Amid the unprecedented happenings, keeping the team motivated was particularly challenging. He remembered the first day at the terminal, just after the COVID news had surfaced, when the entire team was briefed and stationed to welcome the incoming flight. But as soon as the first ten passengers came out, nobody moved; to Sampreeth's surprise, they were frozen on the spot. Understanding the anxiety of his team, he took the lead and started greeting the passengers himself, and his team followed suit shortly after.

From maintaining the highest level of hygiene to working 12-hour long shifts, he led his team from the front. Overseeing the operations on the frontlines must have been taxing on him and his entire team, but they still did the job with a smile.

Recalling a touching anecdote from the early days of COVID, Sampreeth shared how a family with three kids had been held up for hours at the airport after their PCR tests. While waiting, the kids kept asking him about the results every other minute, and he kept answering them playfully. When the results finally came out, the kids walked up to him and said their thanks, and handed him a chocolate, one by one. Perhaps the sweetest reward anyone could have asked for.

Jinesh Joseph's Postal Odyssey





In our lifetimes, how many of us get to hold a record-making title to our name? Only a select few. This is why Jinesh Joseph's story, presently a part of the Emergency Medical Service team at BIAL ARFF, is truly one of its kind.

A paramedic with an ardent passion for philately, Jinesh is the only person in the world to have a collection of airmail covers from around the globe. With a total of 5,000-plus mail, meticulously collected from 193 countries and 145 territories, his feat has been recognised by the Limca Book of World Records.

Jinesh's love for collecting philatelic covers began in early 2013, but he had been an avid stamp collector since his childhood days. Harbouring a natural inclination for exploring the new and yet-unexplored, collecting stamps was his favourite way of passing the time; what many would call a passing adolescent phase had become a cherished creative pursuit, one that remains as fresh as the winter morning dew even today.

The stamp collection was a creative endeavour he wanted to master profoundly but in a systematic manner. This, alongside the collections of other philatelists, inspired him to start a thematic cover collection and create an airmail label design of his own. But the cover-collecting process (especially from remote locations like Penrhyn Island of the Cook Islands or Bougainville Island of Papua New Guinea) was never a walk in the park. The covers would often come back stained or torn, leaving Jinesh with a feeling of bitter disappointment.

However, as social networks started sprouting on the scene, Jinesh discovered fellow philatelists and globe-trotters who shared his enthusiasm. They helped him navigate the strange, and often confusing, postage rules of faraway shores and deliver their respective airmails to the Bangalore International Airport Sub Post Office, PIN 560300, to Jinesh.

On 5th December 2018, the last envelope arrived: from the only missing country in his collection, the Isle of Man. As of now, there is no sovereign nation in the world whose airmail envelopes (and banknote) aren't included in his record-holding collection. One day, Jinesh hopes to write and publish a book about his unique collection of self-designed, postally travelled covers, capturing his experience in cartophilately: to record the mail routes, postal history, people, places, and incidents that brought it to life.

The Art of Watching Birds with Sarvanan

The art of birding is actually a science. It is about moving with the rhythm of the wild, observing mysterious birds through a pair of binocular-clad eyes, and adapting to their movements as they fly around. To capture the slightest of a bird's movement, you'd need the patience of a monk and the precision of a robot. But for Sarvanan, a member of the Environment & Safety Team at BIAL Projects, birding is all about the challenge.

Photography was a childhood hobby for Sarvanan, always trying to find creative angles for capturing subjects in the right light. But after learning how challenging birding photography was, he took up birding for good. Ever since, he has gone on many birding expeditions across South India, travelling to forests, coastal areas, mountains, and bird sanctuaries in search of creatures in their natural habitat.

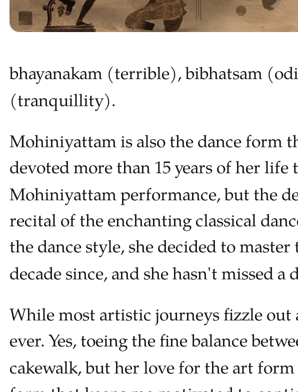
Today, he can easily identify 170 bird species found in India, which he has captured and archived digitally on his social handles.

Oddly enough, birds are also no strangers to the enormous premises of airports. They are typically attracted by the open, vast fields of construction projects, food wastage from nearby hotels, and contaminated or sewage water around airport premises, often posing a significant threat to airport operations. It's a challenge the Project Team has to overcome every single day.

At work, Sarvanan shoulders the responsibility of enforcing contractors to discard food waste properly, provide closed bins, and carry out regular cleaning of debris near project sites, thus keeping the airport premises clean. Routine pest control is also commissioned to keep the rodent population in check and the birds away from preying on them, so that airport operations are never compromised, and neither are the lives of birds.

Unfortunately, for a while now, Sarvanan has had to keep his distance from birding as the pandemic raged on. But once the world is back in order, he would like to pick up the hobby once more and visit birding spots like Hosekot Lake and Valley School, also known as the "paradise for birding photographers."

Sreelekha Nair's Devotion to Mohiniyattam



The classical dance form of Mohiniyattam is all about the torso: one sway to the left and another to the right, with toes moving up and down. Like the sea waves and swaying coconut trees, reminiscent of the land the dance originates from: Kerala.

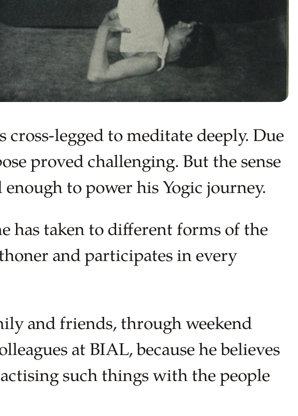
What makes the 'Dance of the Enchantress' so stimulating are the sensuous dance lines and emotive facial expressions. When combined and performed in harmony, they express the nine sentiments known all too well to humankind: sringara (amour), hasyam (comic), karunam (pathetic), raudram (furious), viram (heroic), bhayanakam (terrible), bibhatsam (odious), adbhutham (wonder), and santam (tranquillity).

Mohiniyattam is also the dance form that Sreelekha Nair, a classically trained dancer, has devoted more than 15 years of her life to. She was only a child when she first witnessed a Mohiniyattam performance, but the delicate yet graceful dance technique, abhinaya, and recital of the enchanting classical dance stayed with her for a long time. Mesmerised by the dance style, she decided to master the classical art form herself. It has been over a decade since, and she hasn't missed a day of practice.

While most artistic journeys fizzle out as the artist ages, Sreelekha is still as passionate as ever. Yes, toeing the fine balance between work, family, and passion has never been a cakewalk, but her love for the art form has kept her going. "It's the sheer love of the art form that keeps me motivated to continue pursuing it," she says.

Sadly, she hasn't been able to perform since the COVID-19 outbreak. Before the pandemic put a collective stop on dance recitals, she would give around four to five performances every year, sometimes on her own, and at other times, with her daughter. When the world comes back to normal, Sreelekha wants to perform Mohiniyattam on the stage once again.

A Glimpse of Haridasan's Yogic Life



In 1995, Haridasan, AGM (Bird Aircraft Strike Hazard Management) at BIAL, was representing the Indian Air Force for the Calcutta Football League. While preparing for the event during a camp, he sustained a knee injury, bad enough to keep him away from the game for months on end. But as coincidence would have it, Yoga was newly inducted into the Indian Air Force's PT programme around the same time.

On a friend's suggestion, he decided to try Yoga and physiotherapy in hopes of a quick recovery. This was the beginning of Haridasan's decade-spanning Yoga journey. "The first-ever difficult asana I was introduced to was the Padmasana," Haridasan recalls, a pose, a lotus-like formation, where one sits cross-legged to meditate deeply. Due to his knee injury, holding the resistance from the pose proved challenging. But the sense of calm and control he felt from the asanas was fuel enough to power his Yogic journey.

From simple breathing techniques to Hatha Yoga, he has taken to different forms of the practice, which is probably why, today, he is a marathoner and participates in every running event organised in Bangalore.

Over the years, he has passed the gift of Yoga to family and friends, through weekend sessions out in the open, and more recently to his colleagues at BIAL, because he believes "there is some sort of harmony and happiness in practising such things with the people you value the most."

In the past few years, he has conducted close to four Yoga sessions with 45 BIAL staff members from different divisions, and even more wanted to join. After every session, a valedictory function was held at the 'Missionaries of Charity', where they served and shared food with the destitute. The enthusiastic response from the team always left him pleasantly surprised.

Given the turbulent times we're cruising through, the reach for a discipline teaching stillness and serenity makes perfect sense, and Haridasan has been mastering the practice since the 90s. Today, he leads a department that deals with the unsuspecting behaviour of nature, so keeping a calm mind is the only way he can take control and lull the stress of the experience. Yoga is no longer a physical exercise for Haridasan. It has become his ideal way of life.